

**Independent Review of Wandsworth Council's response
to the Fox House fire, Maysoule Road, Battersea
on Wednesday 10 September 2025**

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The background and context

1. Fox House is a post-war five storey block of 37 'general needs' flats. It is a brick constructed property with a pitched roof. It is one of a series of similar blocks at Maysoule Road in Battersea. At the time of the fire all but one of the properties were occupied - one was being refurbished by its leasehold owner. There were over 100 occupants living in the block: mostly tenants of the Council (29), some leaseholders (five, including the property being refurbished) as well as others three households living there on a temporary licence, while awaiting their permanent rehousing.
2. A multi-generational and diverse community of people lived in the block. Single adults and couples who had lived for decades, and other families with young and growing children who had moved to the block more recently. This was a thriving small community of people with strong attachments to their local area and yet also with wider links to London's economy, public services and educational institutions.
3. Wednesday 10th September 2025 was a cool day in Wandsworth with intermittent light rain. The day was darkening when the fire ignited at Fox House and spread quickly across the roof of the block. Some residents first saw the fire above them reflecting in the windows of the block opposite. One described the horror of watching this reflection, when the full window above their flat was blown out and crash landed on the ground immediately below. Neighbours began to alert each other as to what was happening. It was clear to them that they should all get out as quickly as possible. The balcony walkways enabled a quick self-organised evacuation. This swift neighbourly action was crucial in minimising harm to all who lived there.
4. The London Fire Brigade arrived rapidly at sunset (about 7.20pm). And while the cause of the fire was not clear, the cause of the spread of the fire was obvious. The fire had spread across the roof space in around ten minutes - a space that is several metres wide and more than 50 metres long.

(photo, London Fire Brigade, BBC news)



5. LFB's report of the incident explains how fifteen fire engines and around 100 firefighters were called to the scene on Maysoule Road in Battersea.

“The fourth floor and the roof space of a five-storey residential building were destroyed by fire. Around 150 people (*their then estimate*) were evacuated from the building by fire crews wearing breathing apparatus, with around 60 people displaced. There were no reports of any injuries. Two of the Brigade's 32-metre turntable ladders were used as water towers to help extinguish the fire from height. The Brigade's drone team also attended, providing the Incident Commander with a greater situational awareness of the fire. The Brigade took the first of 42 calls at 1909 and mobilised crews from Battersea, Wandsworth, Fulham, Clapham and other surrounding fire stations to the scene. The fire was brought under control at 2301.”

6. One resident reported to the BBC that, “I opened my door and my neighbour said ‘fire, fire upstairs’. I took my phone which was near me, my house keys, my jacket and I forgot my glasses and I ran downstairs. I crossed over with firemen on the way down and then I came out and I saw the fire coming out of the window really violently.”

(photo: London Fire Brigade, BBC news)



7. The existing Fire Risk Assessment (FRA) for the block was completed by independent experts in 2022. The roof void was not inspected. The recommended safety guidance, for residents in the event of a fire was to ‘stay put’. Given the experience of this incident at Fox House and the relative ease by which most residents were able to evacuate from this walk-up block of four storeys, the implications of these two points may need to be explored further and consideration given to whether FRAs and safety advice to residents need reviewing. No residents were known to have a PEEP - a personal emergency evacuation plan. This is a bespoke plan created for individuals who may need assistance or have specific requirements to evacuate a building (a workplace, care home or residential building) safely during an emergency.

8. An early contact to the Council was from the LFB to the duty officer in building control. Their expertise in building engineering, chartered surveying and especially with assessing dangerous structures, means that LFB have a regular connection with building control on fire related issues with buildings of all types. In this instance, the concern was not simply about fire damage and the impact on the building of water penetration, but also the apparent fragility of chimney stacks and the positioning of electrical cables. Building control were at the site by 11pm and in discussion with LFB. The structure was declared unsafe at the scene. Scaffolding and fencing had to be erected quickly for purposes of public safety - and the formal dangerous structure notice was issued two days later.
9. ***Imagine this:*** you realise, with an immense sense of fear, that there's a raging fire in your roof space. You are desperate to flee. A mixture of adrenaline and common sense compels you to leave as rapidly as you can. But you immediately think, "what do I need to take with me now; what if the whole place is consumed by flames and I lose everything?" My phone, my pet, my purse or wallet - but what about my key identity documents, my glasses, hearing aids, and essential medicines. And what about my treasured personal and family mementos. How long do I have? What shall I leave behind? Everyone who fled Fox House that night had to make this calculation. They were safe - but some of their treasured belongings were lost.

The Council's emergency and civil contingency responsibilities

10. Local authorities are central to disaster management and emergency response, acting as key coordinators and providers of aid within their communities through multi-agency partnerships known as Local Resilience Forums (LRF). Their roles include managing evacuation, providing social support, liaising with other emergency services, and coordinating the long-term recovery process. The Civil Contingencies Act of 2004 designates Councils as "Category 1 Responders" and they are expected to be prepared for emergencies outside of normal working hours.
11. These responsibilities, as a first responder in civil contingencies, apply to the Council as a corporate body and not simply to one or several functions of the Council. As a housing authority and residential building owner, the Council is responsible as a landlord to its tenants and leaseholders. If a boiler breaks down or pipes freeze through, the Council responds through its housing function as a landlord. Its housing management division holds the key responsibility for resolving these building problems.
12. But if over 100 people need to be evacuated from their homes on a long term temporary or permanent basis, this is plainly a corporate responsibility for the Council overall. Of course, the housing function will be centrally involved in any emergency that involves its own housing stock, but it is the Council as a corporate emergency responder which holds prime responsibility for major incidents. Consider for a moment, the response if this incident occurred in a housing association block or in a private residential block.

13. In Wandsworth the housing function has taken the lead for responding to emergencies for many years. This was a pragmatic and sensible approach prior to the 2004 Civil Contingencies Act, as the housing department had some 30,000 homes under management and thereby had considerable experience in dealing with emergency call-outs, organising temporary shelter, and using estate based assets as community rest centres. This contrasts with the position in Richmond, where the transfer of just over 7,000 homes to a housing partnership in the year 2000, meant that adult social care function took the lead on emergency response, in the light of its access, in the case of localised emergencies, to local day care centres.
14. It is important that both Richmond and Wandsworth have the best possible arrangements for responding to emergencies and that the single staff organisation is both robust and flexible in the delivery of responses, in both authorities, to emergencies and in aiding subsequent recovery. The two geographies of the two Councils may present a slightly different pattern of risks but the organisational response needs to be consistently effective, not least because of the scale capabilities that can be drawn upon.
15. Councils often view their primary role as improving service and project delivery. But in truth, community safety, civil resilience and the protection of the public from extreme risks, hazards and harm is a first order requirement on all Councils.
16. The conventional approach for local authorities, in respect of organising themselves for responding to emergencies, involves the development of disciplined emergency and civil contingency plans embedded within wide ranging risk management strategies. To this end, emergency planning teams are corporately engaged on preparedness planning, scenario testing, and ensuring that the whole organisation is suitably trained to be mobilised and deployed in the event of a large scale emergency.
17. These teams also develop an arrangement for strategic, tactical and operational responses through a classic “gold, silver and bronze” framework of control, communication and empowered delegation. The orthodox operating framework for London authorities requires the LALO to have command and control over resources at the scene. In this way the LALO essentially fulfils a ‘bronze commander’ role, while also representing the Silver at on-scene tactical co-ordination group meetings.
18. It was in this context that Richmond and Wandsworth’s chief executive established a new approach to allocating responsibilities to the emergency gold and silver roles only two months before the Fox House fire incident. His aim was to build upon the traditional structures of emergency response by establishing a more corporate response from management across the organisation. The emergency planning team had only recently set a new rota of responsibilities involving a wider range of senior managers than had previously been the case. This approach was in its infancy and was tested and strained by the requirements to respond adequately in the case of the Fox House fire.

Planning is crucial, readiness to respond is vital

19. When an emergency occurs, it's important to refer to the plan - how people and resources are to be organised and deployed, and how communication is to be channelled and disseminated. But actions must be guided by the specific circumstances of the emergency itself; its immediate consequences, its likely spread, in space and time, and its immediate and short-term demands upon the organisation. The original national guidance produced for emergency response was drafted before the iPhone was developed. Of course, it has been updated and revised but the dynamic social media environment proves very challenging in the practice of emergency management in 2025.
20. Video accounts of the Fox House fire and its consequences were available on social media within minutes of the incident starting. Viral spread of video based social media information is the environment in which emergencies now have to be managed. Cascading telephone calls between a hierarchy of officers, most of whom are not actually at the scene, simply won't work adequately in 2025. Events of this scale - with over 100 people evacuated - requires senior managers capable of strategically assessing the people and resources that need to be mobilised immediately; certainly within the first three hours of an incident. In their target response time to a fire, LFB aim to be at the scene within six minutes (with a second fire engine arriving within two minutes of the first). In the field of tackling crime, the police speak of the first golden hour for a successful investigation. In the event of a community emergency, Councils need to consider the commensurate urgency of their response - as the table suggests below, a response within two hours ought to be the outer limit for setting a strategic response.

Fox House fire and the ideal timeline for response

The first two hours	1930 to 2130	situational awareness, set up an integrated response arrange rest centre and urgent accommodation
The next twelve hours	2130 to 0930	transport, personal effects, finance & food
The following day	0930 to 1800	coordinating next practical steps, living for weeks/months without prior possessions (etc), rehousing (temporary and permanent)
Throughout	1930 onwards	communicating with residents, internally, Members, partners, community stakeholders

The initial response

21. The Council's emergency arrangements were stood up at around 7.50. The borough emergency centre (BEC) wasn't set up, but the joint control centre (JCC) and the local authority LALO was on notice and communicating from 8pm. Measured against its

own expectations the organisation's response was adequate and satisfactory. A rest centre was established in the community hall adjacent to the York Gardens Library. A gold (chief executive), silver (a director) and an operational service head acting as a local authority liaison officer (or LALO) were alerted within expected times and the area housing manager was present at the scene by 8pm.

22. From this time the chief executive, as Gold, had been advised of the incident and was in regular contact with both the Council's political leadership and with the officer fulfilling the off-site Silver role. This enabled the Council's leading Members and executive managers to steer the implementation of the response and begin to guide the approach to recovery (especially in terms of rehousing). A regular written briefing from the Council's communications established an effective communication channel for relevant Members (including the local MP) as well as with relevant officers across the authority.
23. In this incident, the Met Police were onsite before Council staff, and so they set up the reception centre - first temporarily in the adjacent Battersea Sports Centre; and then at around 9.30pm it was transferred to the York Gardens Library, by which time the Area Housing Manager had been onsite for some while and was principally engaged sorting hotel accommodation. An experienced LALO arrived at 9.15pm - he had alerted operational staff (carpenters, depot staff, etc) to be on stand by while travelling to the site. Both the LFB and the Met Police responded positively about the Council's initial response and its liaison with them. They both consider that it worked effectively.
24. However, of the more than 100 residents who had evacuated, about two-thirds could not stay overnight with family or friends and required the Council's support. And as the darkness fell and residents thoughts were shifting towards "where are we sleeping tonight", time began to collapse inwards for the officers on the scene. The challenges of arranging urgent hotel accommodation worsened when it was evident that the organisation that was relied upon to deliver was unable to act as rapidly as required. ICAB - the insurance claims accommodation bureaux - found here, icab.org.uk - are specialists in arranging both planned and emergency accommodation. They act on behalf of insurers, social housing organisations and a large range of Instructing Principals. The Area Housing Manager recalled that, on the night, it took over an hour to house one family in a hotel, at which point the scale of the task involved became tangibly evident.
25. This problem was compounded by two constraints; one extraneous, the other caused by internal bureaucracy. The first, was that the tube strike in London had resulted in more commuters staying in the sort of modestly priced hotels usually used by ICAB. The second was that a pre-set £15 taxi voucher limit had the effect of constraining the distance that people could be taken to hotels. It soon became evident to the officers struggling with the rehousing that they had to work around these constraints.

26. Two councillors were present at the York Gardens Library and quickly found a highly valued pastoral role, supporting individuals and families. They soon realised that they were the only women present from the statutory authorities. This is a powerful observation. It was suggested, and without a scintilla of criticism for the dedicated work of all of the officers present, as well as those from the police and the fire service, that a slightly more balanced workforce might have been helpful on the night. For more than half of the evacuated residents in the support centre were women, and children, and yet almost all the staff responding on the ground were men. The councillor I spoke with stayed with residents in the support centre until 5am the next morning, when the last resident left to go to a hotel.
27. There is no question about the sheer hard work and the personal responsibility grasped by those officers on the ground that evening. They were doing their best and making their best judgements - against the odds of not being able to find hotels that night. However, there was a break in the communication chain between those officers on the ground and those who were responsible for the overall response. This can be evidenced in a number of examples: the emergency planner was only able to speak just once to the officer dealing with the overnight stay problem; and the director who was acting as silver was told at 1am that everyone was allocated a hotel room at 1am, and then some 45 minutes later was advised that around 40 people were still in the rest centre and had nowhere to go. There is also little doubt that middle and senior managers stepped up to try to resolve these problems. Some worked throughout the night, and others were still driving families to hotels in Wembley and Teddington in the early hours of the morning.
28. But for many residents it was a shaky start. They did not receive sufficiently reliable and timely information through the evening and the night. They had left their homes in a hurry, and simple things had understandably been left behind - such as a change of clothing or mobile phone chargers. Indeed, everyone's mobile phone seemed to be dying at the same time; the evacuated residents' as well as the mobiles of some of the staff who went to assist. The advice that residents were given was that the ICAB would call them at some time and advise them of hotel arrangements for the night. Some people were left waiting for a call that never came - they made their own arrangements deep into the early hours of the following morning.
29. Moreover, those residents who had evacuated and had stayed in hotels, were advised to go to the homeless families unit the following morning. This seems an unreasonable request in the circumstances. One-third had made their own arrangements that night while two-thirds had been placed in hotels by the Council. Some residents had left key personal belongings in their homes; such as glasses, contact lenses and hearing aids. Very few had an adequate range of clothing and footwear to last them a day, let alone oyster cards or whatever, to enable them to travel. Only some had access to cash. At that point it seemed that those Council's tenants and leaseholders who fled fire in their

homes had, in the immediate aftermath of the fire, to bend towards the bureaucracy of the Council rather than the bureaucracy bend to them.

The following day - a corporate approach emerges

30. Upon the conclusion of a corporate management meeting, acting as LA Gold, early the following day, officers from across the council went to the York Gardens library - which from that time acted as a community support centre - and swiftly established an array of personalised and targeted services for those impacted by the fire.
31. Throughout that day, and the days that followed, a more organised and corporate response developed. Excellent examples were identified where committed and capable staff teams found new ways of helping people to solve their practical problems. The engagement of the local voluntary centre was also evident from that time. The response of the data analytics team was referred to by many staff as enabling personalised responses to be developed swiftly. This enabled a 'caseworker' approach to be devised so that each household was allocated a named worker. It was impressive to hear how staff from across the Council were galvanised to contribute to helping the residents of Fox House solve their urgent and pressing practical challenges and some of their broader needs.
32. It is conventional in emergency response to identify a 'humanitarian' strand of activity. Indeed, Councils are advised to establish a humanitarian assistance liaison officer (a HALO), and usually for unitary Councils the authority's Director of Adult Social Care. In this incident, the executive director performed the HALO role for the first week, and then the director for adult social care for the following two weeks.
33. Humanitarian assistance often seems an awkward term to use in circumstances such as the Fox House fire. People require highly practical and personalised assistance but they may also require a degree of pastoral care. After all, people who lose their homes due to fire are experiencing circumstances of intense personal stress. This pastoral or welfare care, could of course extend into specialist psychotherapeutic support, as well as other support that may be based on a 'trauma informed' approach to dealing with emergency situations.
34. Immediately after an incident of this nature, people urgently require practical, financial and logistical assistance as well as empathic and compassionate support. Balancing this can be difficult for Councils as they tend to approach people through a service functional lens. Nonetheless, Wandsworth officers approached this well. In Wandsworth, despite the perennial problem, that has been identified in many reviews, of allocating named caseworkers to residents, this aspect of the response worked reasonably well. And weeks after the incident, officers are now engaged with a London wide review of key worker or caseworker roles in emergency situations - a review that is

being led by Westminster City Council and is designed on the basis of experience gained in responding to the Grenfell tragedy.

35. In the case of the Fox House fire, financial support was swiftly organised. It took the form of subsistence vouchers of £25 per person per day, school uniform vouchers, 31 laptops, 21 mobile phones, 16 basic furniture packages, and additional furniture packages. There were some short term delays in relation to financial support (say, for purchasing new furniture). This was especially in respect of those households who were uninsured - specifically in terms of their home contents and their urgent need for clothing, furniture and household goods. This type of internal bureaucratic difficulty, is a long standing problem and its consideration follows a well known path. Councils, like all other public authorities, need to have a prudent approach to allocating public money, and in so doing, they need to have regard to 'moral hazard' considerations. But in these circumstances where the Council is the building owner with responsibility for the security and integrity of the building, such considerations can be otiose. In this instance, Wandsworth was flexible in its approach and created a fund for those in urgent need.
36. Officers across the organisation have conducted a detailed internal review of what went right and wrong in respect of their 'lessons learned' work on the Fox House fire incident. They have identified over 25 detailed points that arise from their learning lessons review - some practical, some organisational, some about improved communication channels, and others about being more foresighted. This is a creditable piece of work that has been discussed corporately at the senior management level. They have also identified how they can build on the effective corporate working that occurred in the days after the fire.
37. Corporate working is more than better coordination and sharing information. Corporate working in response to emergencies involves the development of coherent and integrated responses across the organisations many functional areas to bring comfort and stability to those individuals and communities impacted by the incident.
38. However, in the Fox House fire incident, a swift housing response was also required: one in respect of rehousing those tenants and leaseholders who were displaced from their homes; and another in investigating the need for remedial works in other similar blocks in the locality - and possibly beyond.
39. In very short order, the housing department identified alternative permanent accommodation for those who were displaced. A new housing development was near to completion and enabled some households to be offered permanent accommodation very quickly. Within three months (by 3rd December) 23 of the 29 Council tenants had been successfully rehoused; three had accepted offers and were due to move in shortly; and three others were had been made offers but were awaiting to view the properties. Of the five leaseholders, two moved through their own insurance arrangements, two have not approached the council for assistance, and one remains in a hotel as of early December.

40. In respect of remedial works on the other similar or near identical blocks, this work has progressed quickly. A ‘waking watch’ was initiated very speedily to offer vigilant assurance to tenants and leaseholders about alertness to any fire concerns. And a specialist fire protection contractor has been engaged to assess the work that may be required on these other blocks. A schedule of works proposed is already drafted. This is a highly technical issue and requires the best professional expertise. The LFB forensic investigation team has only recently been afforded access to the roof void at Fox House. This has, of course been subject to massive water penetration and a further degree of weathering. And so the precise cause of the fire has yet to be determined. However, the rapid spread of the fire may indicate a weakness of adequate compartmentation in the roof void at Fox House.
41. The housing department have moved swiftly to address this issue. They will need to work together with building control to ensure that the diagnostic inspections of roof voids (and potentially other communal voids in estate blocks), and they may need to engage relevant architectural or surveying expertise to direct and monitor, the contractors involved in rectifying any design or construction deficiencies. I understand that this is precisely what they are engaged with at present. And I applaud their speedy response. They will need, of course, to keep residents, statutory partners and other relevant building owners appropriately aware of the success of these works as they progress.

Member involvement

42. The effective involvement of elected Members is a crucial aspect of successful Council responses to emergencies and civil contingencies. Members know their local areas, they know many of the people in their areas - especially the informal community leaders and the local patchwork of civil associations that make up the fabric of their community. As such Members offer a direct link to those most affected by the disaster. But Members can wear four hats - a member of the political executive, a local ward member, a member of a scrutiny body, and a member of the body corporate - and each hat indicates the differing roles that Members can perform in respect of a Council’s response to an emergency.
43. In November 2025, the Local Government Association (LGA) updated its guidance that is designed to support Councils in strengthening their approach to civil resilience. It provides an overview of the council’s responsibilities in this area, along with targeted sections outlining the role of senior councillors and ward councillors in the event of major incidents, emergencies or civil contingencies in their areas. It is available here: <https://www.local.gov.uk/publications/councillors-guide-civil-resilience>.
44. Members, in both boroughs, have had the opportunity of training and development (Jan 2023, Richmond; and March 2023, Wandsworth) in how to operate in their roles in

emergency situations - those in the political executive and those in their local ward community leadership role. In this area, training involves understanding multi-agency roles and responsibilities in emergencies; the structure of executive management control and delegation (gold, silver, bronze, etc); and also what constitutes appropriate conduct in what can be distressing situations. This is now being refreshed, particularly in the light of updated guidance.

The demands of being a first responder

45. Too few Councils have seriously examined the demands of being a first responder in the event of a major emergency. In 2004 when the Civil Contingencies Act was enacted, Councils tended to make incremental improvements in their emergency planning capability. These were inadequate responses to the new legislation. Instead the substantive challenge for Councils, is whether they have the capacity to respond, the capabilities of responding at scale, and the confidence to act alongside statutory partners as well as civil and community groups.
46. Acting confidently and professionally is a substantive demand. It requires expertise, local knowledge, a sense of public ethics in novel and uncertain situations, and a willingness to go beyond conventional boundaries to get things done. Furthermore, emergencies and civil contingencies can test the legitimacy of public authorities, including Councils, in the court of public opinion. In the case of very large incidents fundamental questions are often aired, such as, “Shouldn’t they have foreseen this? Have they responded properly and fairly”, and so on. One test is the ability to work collaboratively with the other first responders - fire, police and health services - as well as with local community and voluntary groups.
47. In UK emergency management, the term ‘major incident’ is a multi-agency concept that derives from JESIP - the Joint Emergency Services Interoperability Principles. These were created after major incident reviews (e.g. 7/7 in London) highlighted that the main failures were often in how agencies worked together, not in their individual technical capabilities. The announcement of a ‘major incident’ typically features real or potential serious harm, large numbers of people or casualties, major disruption, and a need for exceptional coordination and command beyond normal business-as-usual and standard mutual aid.
48. But Councils also need to respond to ‘critical’ and ‘significant’ incidents. These are usually service-specific escalation levels within an organisation (the NHS, police or a local authority). Who determines whether an incident is critical or significant is set in each organisation’s plan - it mostly relates to the degree or scale as to whether critical infrastructure or services are threatened. Any responder agency can declare a major incident if the JESIP definition is met, whereas critical/significant levels are usually declared by designated managers under their internal policies.

49. In the case of the Fox House fire, the LFB were the lead responder and would, in practice, be 'in charge' of the building until the fire was extinguished. The Council's building control function (in particular, the dangerous structure team) would be responsible for the building, and any subsequent access to it, in liaison with the housing department.
50. The practicalities involved in organising a 24/7 coverage, at the management level, are easily under-estimated. There are 365 days a year; which is 8,760 hours a year. But people are usually employed on contracts that, depending upon their leave arrangements, requires them to work for 210 days - and an average of just 5% for sickness absence takes this down to 200. And as each person will work for 8 hours for each of these 200 days - this produces 1,600 hours a year for each manager. This means that for the equivalent of three people to be on duty the entire year, requires the Council to have at least 17 managers on a duty rota.
51. In practice, duty rotas are particularly difficult to organise to ensure adequate overnight and weekend cover when managers are performing key functional roles on a day-to-day basis. This means that when a 'major incident' happens, the key issue is how to ratchet up and scale up, the management and staffing response. This is especially important in the period from 6pm during weekdays and over weekends. It requires a change of mindset among those managers and staff who perform these vital response roles. In emergencies everyone needs to have role clarity and be given clear tasks to perform and empowered to deliver for citizens - usually extending beyond their usual parameters, to ensure a coherent, complete and satisfactory response.

Summary

52. Overall the response of the Council's organisation to the Fox House fire can be described in outline by four parts. First, a highly demanding set of challenges that began at 7pm with the rapid spread of the fire, was addressed by excellent work on the part of staff and councillors. With dedication, they worked hard into the night, extending into early the next morning. But, as there often is in the first few hours of an emergency, there were practical, logistical and communication missteps that hampered the first few hours of their aspect of the multi-agency response. Things could have been organised more smoothly and satisfactorily for those residents who were evacuated and who needed urgent overnight accommodation.
53. Second, the Council's organisational response improved dramatically from the following morning. Corporate working was evident and staff from across the Council's functional areas stepped forward to help those most affected by the incident. Working from the community support centre and across the authority.
54. Third, the response of the housing department to rehousing people has been excellent. In very short order, the housing department identified alternative accommodation for

those who were displaced. Just three months after the Fox House fire a total of 23 households, out of 29 Council tenants, have accepted the offer of a permanent alternative home; three have accepted properties and are planning to move; while three others have yet to view and accept their property offers. Of course, the five leaseholders have had to grapple with many issues directly themselves - one experiencing great difficulties gaining financial support from the relevant insurance companies. This latter case is (in the second week of December) in the process of being resolved by the Council's financial services team. In respect of rehousing tenants, credit must also go to the leading members in the political executive who gave clear direction to officers and who promptly agreed the proposals to rehouse the displaced residents of the Fox House fire as a Council priority.

55. Fourth, the housing department was quick to recognise the potentially wider problem that the Fox House fire alerted them to. A 'waking watch' was initiated very speedily to offer vigilant assurance to tenants and leaseholders in neighbouring blocks. And a specialist fire protection contractor has been engaged to assess the work that may be required on these other blocks. This is a highly technical issue and requires the best professional expertise. The housing department have moved swiftly to address this issue. They will need, of course, to keep residents, statutory partners and other relevant building owners appropriately aware of the success of these works as they progress.

Recommendations

Organisational leadership and Gold/Silver/Bronze

1. Strengthen and formalise the Gold, Silver and Bronze arrangements, including a clear, sustainable duty rota of senior managers, so that the Council can scale up rapidly and confidently when incidents occur. Adopt the appropriate involvement of Members of the political executive, local ward councillors and those exercising a scrutiny role in the governance and oversight of relevant decisions and actions.
2. In any incident that meets the JESIP definition of a major incident, ensure that a senior director with delegated authority to commit resources is physically on site within two hours of the incident being declared, in close liaison with the Bronze/LALO and with clear lines of communication to Gold.
3. Make explicit, and routinely brief on, the protocols for decision-making, escalation and governance (including the roles of the political executive, scrutiny, and corporate management) in emergency situations.

Operational readiness and systems

4. Review "grab bag" arrangements for the essential materials needed by onsite staff (phones, chargers, preset household identification reports, etc). Recognise the reality of ubiquitous, real-time and viral social media, and ensure that formal communication

channels are continuous, dynamic and well-coordinated, providing clear, calm and accurate information to affected residents, councillors, partners and the wider public.

5. Ensure that control of all key contractors and commissioned providers are visible to on-site management as well as to those operating in Gold, Silver, Bronze and LALO roles, with the ability to escalate or switch providers quickly if needed.
6. Review the current arrangements with ICAB and test whether they can reliably meet the time-critical demands of large-scale evacuations; if not, explore more robust and scalable arrangements, potentially on a pan-London or sub-regional basis, with other councils and housing providers for emergency hotel and serviced accommodation.

Residents, humanitarian support and members

7. Embed a consistently corporate and humanitarian approach in all incidents, ensuring that processes, financial controls and eligibility rules can flex in the immediate aftermath so that residents are not required to “fit” standard service pathways when they have just lost access to their homes and possessions.
8. Train and develop managers and staff to operate in fully corporate responses, including joint training and exercising with statutory partners and voluntary sector organisations, so that role clarity, delegated authority and expectations are understood before an incident occurs.
9. Provide dedicated training and guidance for councillors, in line with the updated LGA councillors’ guide to civil resilience, covering their roles as ward members, executive members, scrutineers and corporate guardians, and how they should operate safely and constructively in emergency situations.

Technical learning and building safety

10. Seek further expert advice on both the cause of the fire and the rapid spread within the roof space, and on the full range of feasible remedial and rectification works across Fox House and similar blocks, drawing on specialist fire engineering, architectural and surveying expertise.
11. Work jointly across housing, building control and relevant external experts to design and deliver a programme of diagnostic inspections of roof voids and other communal voids, and to oversee any remedial works required, ensuring that residents and statutory partners are kept appropriately informed as this programme progresses.
12. When appropriate, issue notifications and share learning with other building owners, landlords and professional bodies so that, when the full facts are known, the lessons from the Fox House fire inform wider practice on compartmentation, roof construction and fire spread in similar post-war blocks.

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Barry Quirk qualified in housing management and then worked for ten years in the housing service in three London Boroughs. He then worked in corporate programme delivery in two councils before being appointed as a chief executive in the London Borough of Lewisham, where he worked from 1993 until June 2017. In June 2017, he was drafted by Government and the LGA to support the response to the Grenfell Tower fire tragedy. In September 2017 he was formally appointed as the chief executive at Royal Borough of Kensington and Chelsea, and worked for five years re-shaping the Council's governance and management, while re-fashioning the response to the thousands of bereaved, survivors and local communities that were impacted by the Grenfell tower fire.

31 December 2025